Finding and reading research papers

Introductory dendrochronology · A guide for undergraduate learners

Why read original research?

Textbooks and reviews introduce a field. An original research paper lets you examine the question, specimens, methods, observations and limits behind a result. Original studies can also contain errors or limitations; check later research and any corrections.

Record the citation

Keep the authors, year, title, journal, volume and issue, pages or article number, and DOI. A search snippet or abstract is not a complete account of the methods and findings.

Open a DOI

A DOI identifies a research output. Place https://doi.org/ before the DOI to make a link. For example, the Yoshino cedar study used in this course is:

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.dendro.2026.126572

Check the title and authors on the resulting page, then look for the abstract, full text, supplementary material and data. A DOI does not guarantee free access to the full text: a subscription or purchase may be required. Availability can change, so check the current page.

When the full text is unavailable

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Example request to an author

Subject

Request for a copy of your paper: [paper title]

Message

Dear Dr. [Surname],

My name is [name], and I am a student at [institution]. I am studying dendrochronology and would like to read your paper, “[title]” ([year], DOI: [DOI]). I am particularly interested in [brief reason or topic].

I have checked my library and available open versions but have not been able to access the full text. If possible, could you share a copy that I may read for my personal study or research?

Thank you for considering my request.

Best regards, [name and affiliation]

After reading

Summarize the question, sample origins and size, methods, results and stated limitations in your own words. Check the version actually read and cite the source when using its ideas or figures.

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